

Unity Education Trust: September 2023 Visits

Data Protection Visit Report: September 2023

Unity Education Trust

DPO: James England

Schedule:

School / Site	Date of visit (2023)	Time
Highgate Infant School	Weds 20 Sep	postponed
Roseberry	Weds 20 Sep	11:00
St Germans Academy	Weds 20 Sep	13:00
Magdalen Academy	Weds 20 Sep	14:30
Locksley	Thurs 21 Sep	12:30
Hooper Lane	Thurs 21 Sep	14:30
Belton	Fri 22 Sep	09:00
Earthsea	Fri 22 Sep	13:00
Dereham Sixth Form College	Fri 22 Sep	14:30

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Main comments

Overall, there were not as many observations to record as on previous visits and whilst nowhere was perfect, there were very few observations to record.

All locations have minimal uncontrolled data on display. Indeed there was nothing found in some settings on this set of visits.

There is a good use of, and reliance on electronic systems. Staff consider that this provides clear benefits.

Previous visits indicated that there was considerable pupil tracking conducted on spreadsheets (behaviour, progress, attendance). This was not found on this visit.

All sites had awareness posters visible in classrooms and offices and feedback appeared to indicate that staff felt these had a positive impact on behaviour.

Sign-in - consideration should be given to an electronic sign-in system to ensure consistency across all sites as well as ease of administration. Whilst some sites have small number of visitors, e-sign in can be beneficial. There is an appreciation that such systems can be costly, however DPE hopes to be able to provide an affordable system for schools by early 2024.

Inconsistencies were mainly around records management - especially of legacy files, including student and personnel - as well as those relating to previous Central Trust working at St Germans. It was not always able to access the archive storage areas and sometimes data was not stored securely at all.

A consideration should be given to converting a room at Hooper Lane to be a dedicated archive for all organisations in the Trust in order to free up limited space for storage in each setting (particularly the smaller settings).

The biggest risk in classrooms is staff having admin applications open when sharing to the whiteboard. No admin applications should be open when connected to the whiteboard, even if not being used at the time due to risk of data breach (see this article)
<https://dataprotection.education/best-practice-update/365-the-ico-reprimands-a-school>

Specific location observations are listed below.

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The Roseberry School

Physical security of the site should be considered a risk.

Archive unavailable to view, however DPE informed that work had been undertaken to check and clean up over summer.

Reception, office and classrooms generally good with little personal data on display.

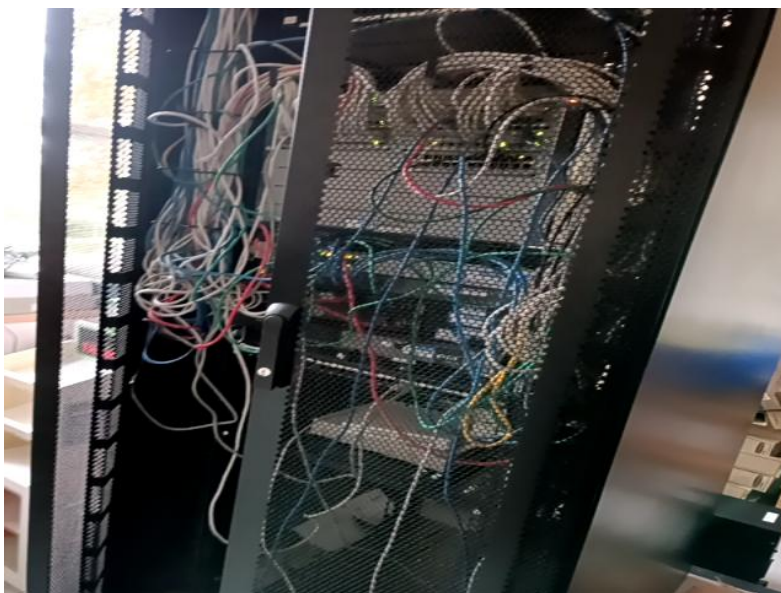
St Germans

Only one member of admin team available to show DPE round the site. The meeting was further disrupted by a fixed-term exclusion. This exacerbated the Overall feeling that there was little time available to dedicate to data protection, but that they were doing as best as they could.

Confidential waste bag used in school office - suggest use of bins rather than bags alone.

Questions were asked about retention - some old documents still being stored...partial pupil files that had not been passed on to the following secondary as "they don't want them". DPE advise is to securely destroy the files and send entire pupil file to the following school in future.

These were located in the server room. The server room was hot as the air conditioning was not working - this is a risk to the operating integrity of the hardware and the data it contains. Additionally, the server cage was not locked. This should be taken up with the IT contractor - it is their responsibility to ensure that hardware fits in the rack and is secure.



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This room also contained other documents and whilst a storage cupboard outside the room was filled with boxes marked for deletion, it wasn't clear what some, if not all the content contained in the server room was.

Data left in bags (in the corridor behind the staff room) - this was data relating to the Central trust team who had previously been based at the school. This should be secured and stored centrally by the trust.



Magdalen Academy

Nothing specific to report in relation to visible data risks throughout the setting.

There is an issue regarding storage space with one storage cupboard containing everything, including some archived files in boxes and a single unsecured desktop PC-type server.

Locksley

Again, excellent in relation to visible data risks on site. A clear improvement from our previous visit.

Physical security excellent (as would be expected at this setting) and staff incredibly vigilant towards personal and data risks.

Archive unable to be viewed, due to site manager not being physically present during visit. Unclear as to volume and state of storage.

Hooper Lane

Site no longer in use as a school, though assessments still taking place on site.

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One incomplete assessment form left on a table just outside the assessment centre.

All other rooms are empty or occupied by administrative staff, with no visible data on display and rooms locked when unoccupied.

Belton

Again, excellent in relation to visible data risks on site.

IPS all electronic and no paper.

There has recently been a clear-out and there is a small room containing old pupil files. The current strategy is to keep them and top-up the confidential waste bins with files each time before they are emptied. This could be a slow-strategy and consideration should be given to the provision of additional one-off services to clear this old content from the premises.

Earthsea

There was nothing of note at the Earthsea site on this visit.

Dereham VI Form

There was nothing of note at Dereham VI Form on this visit.